DOCTORAL THESIS

FILM · POLITICS · FEMINISM

LEVIATHAN'S MOTHER

Preservative Sovereignty, Artificial Persons, and the Parasitology of Capital in James Cameron's Aliens *(1986)*

A dissertation in film philosophy, political theory, and feminist criticism

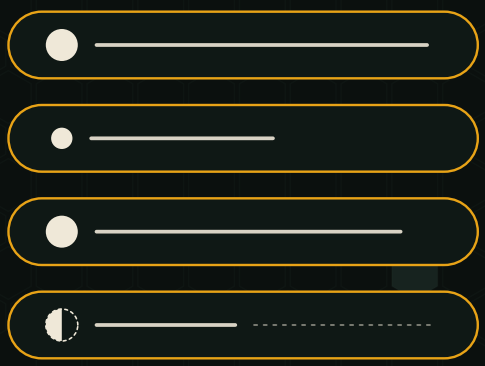


FIG. 0 — THE COMMONWEALTH OF THE PRESERVED

OCTOBER 2026

ABSTRACT

THIS DISSERTATION READS JAMES Cameron's *Aliens* (1986) as a work of political philosophy conducted by cinematic means. Its reception has oscillated between antinomies: Ellen Ripley as the inaugural action heroine and Ripley as the patriarchal recapture of a feminist icon; the film as an anti-imperial allegory of Vietnam and as a Reaganite fantasy of refighting that war and winning it; Bishop as an emblem of posthuman solidarity and the climax as an exterminationist apotheosis of the human. The study contends that these antinomies are not interpretive errors awaiting adjudication but symptoms of the question the film actually poses: on what ground can legitimate authority be refounded once the patriarchal-corporate commonwealth has dissolved into a state of nature?

The argument proceeds in three movements. The first reconstructs the film's intellectual genealogy: the Conradian armature legible in the franchise's ship names; the Heinleinian military imaginary that Cameron conscripted and inverted; the insect-collectivist tradition running from Mandeville and Maeterlinck through *Them!* (1954) to E. O. Wilson's sociobiology; and the parasitological imagination Darwin confronted in the ichneumon wasp. The second places this genealogy in sustained dialogue with political philosophy (Hobbes, Locke, Marx, Weber, Arendt, Schmitt, Benjamin, Foucault, Agamben, Esposito), feminist theory (Wollstonecraft, Bachofen and Engels, Beauvoir, Firestone, Rich, Ruddick, Kristeva, Irigaray, Pateman, Haraway, Federici), psychoanalysis (Freud, Klein, Winnicott), the humanist and anti-humanist traditions (Pico, Montaigne, Kant, Sartre, Camus, Fanon, Foucault, Lyotard, Braidotti), and a comparative archive of feminist and humanist fiction from *Frankenstein* and *Herland* to Octavia E. Butler's "Bloodchild," Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale*, Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time*, and Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction." The third advances an original synthesis.

That synthesis identifies three rival regimes of reproduction organizing the film's world. A *generative* regime, embodied by the Hive and its Queen, reproduces life without a world. An *accumulative* regime, embodied by Weyland-Yutani, reproduces capital through bodies it neither owns nor answers for. A *preservative* regime, improvised by Ripley, reproduces a world by guarding lives it did not generate. The

film's two Leviathans—the Hive, which literalizes the frontispiece of Hobbes's commonwealth as a sovereign body woven from captive human bodies, and the Company, which Hobbes himself anatomized as "worms in the entrails of a natural man"—are defeated by a third sovereignty whose charter *Leviathan* also supplies, in a neglected doctrine of its twentieth chapter: in the state of nature, dominion lies with the mother, and with whoever preserves the child.

From this convergence the dissertation develops a theory of *preservative sovereignty* in four propositions: that preservation, rather than generation or contract, founds legitimate dominion; that the corporation and the chestburster are homologous parasitic forms; that the power-loader climax stages a *prosthetic natality* in which technē rather than biology bears the human capacity to begin anew; and that the closing tableau of woman, orphan, wounded soldier, and bisected android composes a counter-frontispiece—a commonwealth of the preserved—which answers both reproductive futurism and its queer-theoretical critique with a third orientation, *preservative futurism*. A final assessment confronts the violence, partiality, whiteness, and colonial residues of the preservative order, and its systematic unmaking in the franchise's later installments.

FRONT MATTER

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NOTE ON THE TEXT, VERSIONS, AND CITATION

Aliens exists in two principal versions whose divergences are interpretively consequential. The theatrical release (Twentieth Century Fox, 18 July 1986; c. 137 minutes) and the Special Edition later prepared under Cameron's supervision for home video (c. 154 minutes) differ chiefly by three restorations. The first is the scene at Gateway Station in which Burke informs Ripley that her daughter, Amanda, has died of old age during the fifty-seven years of her drift. The second is an extended prologue at Hadley's Hope in which the Jorden family, acting on orders relayed from the Company, reaches the derelict ship and the father becomes the colony's first host. The third is the automated sentry-gun sequence of the siege.

The Amanda scene converts Ripley's attachment to Newt from an elective bond into a substitutive and reparative one. The Hadley's Hope prologue renders the Company's culpability visible before Ripley discovers it, and installs the father as the first casualty of the infestation. This dissertation treats the Special Edition as the fuller articulation of the film's philosophical design while marking, wherever it matters, what the theatrical cut withholds; the variance between the cuts is itself treated as evidence (section 4.2).

Scenes are cited by narrative position rather than timecode, given the instability of running times across formats. Dialogue is quoted sparingly and in fragments, and is otherwise paraphrased. Hobbes is cited by chapter of *Leviathan* (1651) in modernized spelling; other pre-twentieth-century works by chapter, section, or line; modern scholarship by author and date, with full references in the Works Cited.

INTRODUCTION

00

THE SEQUEL AS A PROBLEM OF SOVEREIGNTY

“If there be no contract, the dominion is in the mother.”

— Thomas Hobbes, Leviathan (1651), ch. XX

“... the great number of corporations, which are as it were many lesser commonwealths in the bowels of a greater, like worms in the entrails of a natural man.”

— Thomas Hobbes, Leviathan, ch. XXIX

“I would annex the planets if I could.”

— Cecil Rhodes, as recorded by W. T. Stead (1902)

I.1 The antinomies of reception

FEW FILMS OF THE American 1980s have been claimed so persistently by incompatible readings as *Aliens*. For one critical line, inaugurated in the popular press of 1986 and consolidated in the feminist film scholarship of the following decade, Ripley is the founding figure of the female action hero: the first woman in mainstream American cinema to occupy without apology the narrative position of the armed protagonist, and one whose performance drew a Best Actress nomination from an Academy that had rarely honored the genre (Tasker 1993; Brown 1996; Gallardo and Smith 2004). For a second line, the same film is the paradigmatic instance of recuperation. The androgynous survivor of Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979), whose sexual indeterminacy derived from a screenplay that specified every role as interchangeable between men and women, is reterritorialized as a mother; her violence is licensed only insofar as it defends a child; and her antagonist is reduced to a monstrous maternal double whose destruction purges the feminine of its archaic power (Rushing 1989; Doane 1990; Creed 1993). Between these poles lies a substantial literature—the essays gathered in Annette Kuhn's two *Alien Zone* collections (1990, 1999), Vivian Sobchack's phenomenology of science-fiction space (1987), Thomas Doherty's genre analysis of the trilogy (1996), and Catherine Constable's account of the series' morphologies of identity (1999)—that has mapped the terrain this study crosses.

The antinomy recurs at every level of the text. The film is an anti-imperial allegory of Vietnam, in which a technologically superior expeditionary force is annihilated by an enemy it cannot see, an analogy Cameron himself acknowledged. It is also a Reaganite fantasy of refighting the lost war and winning it this time, composed by the writer who had just drafted *Rambo: First Blood Part II* (1985) (Jeffords 1989, 1994). It is a humanist parable in which an android proves more humane than a corporate executive, and an exterminationist one in which the moral climax is the incineration of a nursery. It indicts capital, and it ends in a tableau resembling the nuclear family that capital has historically required.

Scholarship has generally answered these antinomies in one of two ways. It has adjudicated, determining which reading the film "really" supports; or it has diagnosed incoherence, treating the text as a site of unresolved ideological contradiction in the manner of the symptomatic reading Fredric Jameson canonized as the political unconscious (Jameson 1981). Neither procedure is adequate. Adjudication flattens a dialectical structure into a verdict; the diagnosis of incoherence mistakes for contradiction what is better understood as a problem being worked through. The present study proposes that the antinomies of *Aliens* are generated by a single question,

posed with remarkable systematicity. Once the institutions that claim to protect life—the corporation, the military, the state, the patriarchal family—have revealed themselves indifferent or hostile to the lives in their keeping, on what ground may legitimate authority be refounded? This is, in the strict sense, a question of sovereignty: of who may decide, under what title, over whom, and toward what end.

I.2 Method: film as philosophizing, genealogy, constellation

The study combines three procedures. First, it treats the film, after Stanley Cavell (1979) and Stephen Mulhall (2002), as itself a site of philosophical thought rather than an illustration of theses formulated elsewhere. Mulhall's reading of the *Alien* cycle as a sustained meditation on embodiment, reproduction, and the conditions of human individuality is the most important precedent for this dissertation and its most persistent interlocutor. Second, it practices intellectual genealogy, reconstructing the sources on which Cameron demonstrably drew—literary, cinematic, scientific, and political—in order to measure the distance the film travels from them rather than to reduce it to its origins.

Third, it proceeds by constellation, in the sense Walter Benjamin and Theodor Adorno gave the term (Adorno 1973): it brings into proximity texts whose conjunction illuminates the film without asserting that Cameron read them. When the dissertation observes that the Hive's walls of cocooned colonists literalize the frontispiece of *Leviathan*, or that Bishop's preferred self-description repeats Hobbes's juridical category of the artificial person, it makes no claim about intention. It claims that the film's images think in a register the canon of political philosophy has already mapped, and that their juxtaposition produces knowledge neither term yields alone.

A word on register. *Aliens* is a commercial genre film, made at speed under studio constraint, and its philosophical density is in part an effect of genre's capacity to condense diffuse collective anxieties into concrete figures. Science fiction, in Darko Suvin's classic formulation, is the literature of cognitive estrangement, organized around a novum that renders the empirical world newly legible (Suvin 1979). The estranging novum of *Aliens* is not finally the creature, which the film inherited, but the configuration of reproductive, economic, and political forces the creature makes visible. The study accordingly reads with neither condescension nor inflation: it takes seriously what the film thinks while attending to what it cannot think.

I.3 Thesis

Aliens stages a contest among three regimes of reproduction, each of which grounds a claim to sovereignty. The **generative** regime of the Hive grounds sovereignty in fecundity: the Queen rules because she bears, and her commonwealth realizes, with a perfection no human polity can attain, Hobbes's ideal of a single will—achieved not by covenant but by eusocial instinct. The **accumulative** regime of Weyland-Yutani grounds sovereignty in the self-expansion of capital, which, like the parasitoid it seeks to weaponize, propagates itself through bodies it does not own and does not mourn. Between them, and against both, Ripley improvises a **preservative** regime, which grounds sovereignty in neither birth nor contract but in the act of keeping alive a life one did not generate.

Hobbes, usually read as the theorist of sovereignty founded in fear and covenant, supplies the charter of this third regime in a passage of *Leviathan* that political theory long neglected and that Carole Pateman recovered for feminist critique (Pateman 1988). In the condition of mere nature, Hobbes argues, dominion over the child belongs to the mother; and if she exposes it and another nourishes it, dominion passes to the nourisher, "for it ought to obey him by whom it is preserved" (*Leviathan* XX). Preservation is the concept that allows the film's antinomies to be thought together rather than adjudicated. It is maternal without being biological, which dissolves the opposition between the celebratory and the recuperative feminist readings. It is armed without being militarist, which reorders the relation between the Vietnam allegory and its Reaganite double. It is humanist without being anthropocentric, since its most scrupulous practitioner besides Ripley is an android. And it is political without being contractual, since it founds obligation in an act rather than an agreement.

The dissertation names the resulting political form *preservative sovereignty*, its ontological correlate *prosthetic natality*, and its temporal orientation *preservative futurism*. It insists equally on the concept's aporias. Preservation is partial: it preserves these lives at the cost of those. It is violent. It culminates in the destruction of an entire local population of a social species, eggs included. The film codes this as pest control; on the film's own comparison of species, it would be genocide, Raphael Lemkin's 1944 term for the destruction of a group as such—a term framed in law for human groups, which is precisely the boundary the film's comparison puts in question. It founds dominion even as it disclaims ownership. And it remains entangled with the colonial captivity narrative it partially revises, as the racial composition of its surviving commonwealth makes plain.

I.4 Plan of the work

Chapter 1 reconstructs the film's genealogy: its inheritance from *Alien*; the Conradian armature of its nomenclature; its inversion of Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* and its affinity with Haldeman's *The Forever War*; the insect-collectivist tradition from Mandeville to *Them!* and E. O. Wilson; and the conjuncture of 1986 in which Cameron composed it. Chapter 2 reads the Hive and the Company as rival Leviathans, developing from Hobbes, Marx, Locke, Serres, Foucault, Agamben, and Esposito a parasitology of sovereignty. Chapter 3 analyzes the collapse of the armed commonwealth: the disarming of Weber's state, the dissolution of the soldier male's armored body, the Vietnam unconscious, and the racial logic of the bug hunt.

Chapter 4, the longest, stages the film's encounter with feminist theory—from Mulvey and Clover through Kristeva, Creed, Rich, Ruddick, and Irigaray—and with a comparative archive of feminist fiction, culminating in a reading of the egg-chamber truce as the film's moral center. Chapter 5 turns to humanism and its critics through the figures of Bishop and Burke. Chapter 6 develops the film's politics of natality through Hobbes, Pateman, Arendt, Edelman, Freud, and Winnicott. Chapter 7 formalizes the original thesis in four propositions and states its aporias. The Conclusion considers the afterlife of the preservative commonwealth.

CHAPTER 1

01

GENEALOGIES

Conrad's Ships, Heinlein's Troopers, and the Inherited Monst

1.1 The inheritance of Alien

CAMERON INHERITED NOT A premise but a fully articulated mythology. Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979)—from a screenplay by Dan O'Bannon on a story by O'Bannon and Ronald Shusett, revised by the producers Walter Hill and David Giler—had fused the low-budget creature feature with the biomechanical surrealism of H. R. Giger. Its cinematic ancestors were *It! The Terror from Beyond Space* (1958) and Mario Bava's *Planet of the Vampires* (1965); its contested literary ones were A. E. van Vogt's pulp stories of 1939; and Giger's *Necronomicon* (1977) announced in its title a debt to Lovecraft's cosmic horror.

Three features of that inheritance proved decisive for the sequel. The first was the reproductive cycle itself, modeled on the parasitoid wasps whose larvae consume their hosts from within: egg, facehugger, implanted embryo, chestburster, adult. The cycle is an image of rape, and in *Alien* its first victim is a man. Dan O'Bannon described the facehugger's attack on Kane in interviews as the oral rape of a man, designed to make male spectators undergo a violation that horror conventionally reserves for women; the implantation it leaves kills the host when the embryo emerges. The second was the Company's directive, revealed in Special Order 937, that the organism be returned for analysis and the crew treated as expendable. The phrase establishes the franchise's founding moral asymmetry: an employer that values a specimen above the workers who carry it. The third was Ripley herself, whose gender the screenplay had left open

and whose survival Scott's film staged as the triumph of procedural competence over both the monster and Ash, the android science officer who serves the Company's order.

James Kavanagh's early and influential reading located *Alien*'s ideological center not in the creature but in the contest between a feminist-humanist ethic embodied by Ripley and a corporate-scientistic antihumanism embodied by Ash and the Company (Kavanagh 1980). Barbara Creed relocated it in the maternal: the derelict's womb-like interior, the egg chamber, and the ship's computer, called "Mother," compose for her an archaic maternal imaginary that the film both fears and pursues (Creed 1986, 1993). *Aliens* literalizes both readings. Ash's antihumanism returns in Burke, now without a mechanical alibi, while the maternal imaginary is reembodied in two antagonists: the computer called Mother is gone, and its function migrates to the Queen and to Ripley.

The sequel's plural title is itself an argument. *Alien* confronts a singular creature, an individual enemy, the classical object of the sovereign right to kill. *Aliens* confronts a population. In Foucault's terms, the shift from the singular to the plural is the shift from a sovereign power exercised over bodies to a biopolitics exercised over populations—their birth rates, their reproduction, their territorial distribution (Foucault 1978, 2003). Pluralization changes the creature's ontology: it is no longer a monster but a species, with a social structure, a sovereign, and a reproductive economy. An oft-repeated and perhaps embellished anecdote has Cameron pitching the sequel by writing its title on a board and converting the final *S* into a dollar sign. Whatever its accuracy, the story condenses the film's deepest homology: the pluralization of the alien and the logic of capital are one operation.

The pluralization of the alien and the logic of capital are one operation.

1.2 The Conradian armature

The franchise names its vessels after Joseph Conrad. The *Nostromo* of 1979 takes its name from Conrad's 1904 novel of silver, revolution, and foreign capital in the fictional republic of Costaguana; Ripley's escape shuttle, the *Narcissus*, from the ship of his 1897 sea novella, published in Britain as *The Nigger of the "Narcissus"* and in the United States, under a title that dropped the slur, as *The Children of the Sea*; and the warship of *Aliens*, the *Sulaco*, from the port city through which *Nostromo*'s silver flows to the world market. One of the franchise's names thus comes from a book whose title designates its Black sailor, James Wait, by a racial slur, a fact that belongs with the racial reading of section 3.4. The nomenclature is not decoration. It installs a precise thematic inheritance: Conrad's analysis of "material interests" as a quasi-sovereign force that subordinates states, revolutions, and private loyalties to the circulation of value. In *Nostromo* the American financier Holroyd, who backs the San Tomé mine as a personal enthusiasm, forecasts an age in which "we shall run the world's business whether the world likes it or not." Weyland-Yutani is Holroyd's heir at interstellar scale: a capital that has outgrown the states that once chartered it.

Heart of Darkness (1899) supplies the film's narrative skeleton and its moral vertigo. Marlow's ascent of the river to the Company's Inner Station becomes Ripley's descent through the atmosphere processor to the nest, a voyage into a "heart" that turns out to be maternal. Conrad's Company, like Cameron's, is never seen whole; it is administered by managers whose banality is the medium of its violence. The novella's two most notorious utterances bracket the sequel's ethics. Marlow's reflection that the conquest of the earth, looked into too much, is not a pretty thing anticipates the film's exposure of colonial terraforming; Kurtz's scrawled postscript, "Exterminate all the brutes!", anticipates Ripley's proposal to "nuke the entire site from orbit." The film distributes Conrad's two figures across its heroine: she advocates Kurtz's solution and lives, like Marlow, to narrate a horror the authorities will not believe.

Hannah Arendt read *Heart of Darkness* as a founding document of imperialist consciousness, the record of a phantom world in which Europeans, released from the restraints of the metropole, discovered that everything was permitted. She opened her account of imperialism with Cecil Rhodes's lament that the world was nearly parcelled out and his wish to annex the planets (Arendt 1951). She also identified the "boomerang effect" by which methods perfected in the colonies return to the metropole—an analysis Aimé Césaire extended in arguing that fascism was colonial violence turned upon Europe (Césaire 1972). Burke's plan to smuggle the organism back to Earth inside human bodies is the boomerang made literal.

Chinua Achebe's indictment of Conrad completes the genealogy from the other side. *Heart of Darkness*, Achebe argued, uses Africa as a backdrop against which a European mind disintegrates, denying Africans the standing of human interlocutors (Achebe 1977). The xenomorph—the term the film introduces into the franchise's lexicon—is the logical limit of that procedure: a colonized population with no language, no perspective, and no face, until, as Chapter 4 argues, the film permits its Queen a single moment of facing.

1.3 From Starship Troopers to The Forever War

Cameron reportedly required the actors playing Colonial Marines to read Robert A. Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959), and the film's military idiom—drop ships, powered exoskeletons, contemptuous references to the enemy as "bugs"—descends from it. Heinlein's novel is a work of political philosophy in its own right. Its classroom sequences in History and Moral Philosophy argue that the franchise should be earned through federal service, that civic virtue is forged in the acceptance of risk for the collective, and that force has settled more historical questions than any other agent. Its enemy, the Arachnids, are a eusocial species organized by caste—workers, warriors, brains, and queens—whose collectivism figures, in the Cold War idiom of 1959, a communism without individuals.

Cameron borrows the apparatus and inverts the philosophy. Heinlein's Mobile Infantry triumph through discipline and the moral seriousness of citizen-soldiers; Cameron's marines are corporate escorts in all but name, swaggering, under-led, and slaughtered within an hour of contact. Their bravado—Hudson asks whether the mission will be a stand-up fight or "another bug hunt"—is Heinlein's confidence reduced to reflex. Where Heinlein reserved piloting for women and combat for men, Cameron keeps a female drop-ship pilot, Ferro, but places women in the infantry, Vasquez foremost among them, and finally hands command to a civilian woman whose military training consists of a single weapons lesson.

Joe Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974), written by a wounded Vietnam veteran as a reply to Heinlein, is the closer philosophical kin. Haldeman's soldiers return from relativistic campaigns to an Earth transformed beyond recognition by the time dilation of their journeys; the war proves to have begun in misunderstanding; and peace arrives only when humanity has itself become a cloned collective, a hive. Ripley's fifty-seven years of drift reproduce Haldeman's temporal exile precisely: she wakes into a world that has consumed her daughter's entire life. And Haldeman's ending poses the

question *Aliens* represses and its sequels reopen—whether victory over the hive requires becoming one.

1.4 The insect commonwealth

The Hive enters the film already freighted with three centuries of political allegory. Bernard Mandeville's *Fable of the Bees* (1714) made the hive the model of commercial society, whose public prosperity arises from private vices. Maurice Maeterlinck's *The Life of the Bee* (1901) mystified it as the expression of a collective "spirit of the hive" to which individual will is sacrificed. William Morton Wheeler's 1911 essay on the ant colony as an organism inaugurated the scientific concept of the superorganism, which E. O. Wilson systematized in *The Insect Societies* (1971) and extended, amid notorious controversy, to human behavior in *Sociobiology* (1975). The Hive of *Aliens* condenses this tradition, and its politics are correspondingly overdetermined: a Mandevillean economy without private vice, a Maeterlinckian spirit without poetry, a Wilsonian superorganism whose reproductive caste structure is the explicit object of the Company's scientific and commercial interest.

The cinematic hive is equally specific. Gordon Douglas's *Them!* (1954), in which atomic testing produces giant ants that colonize the storm drains of Los Angeles, contains in embryo much of the second half of *Aliens*. It opens with a small girl found wandering the desert in catatonic shock, a doll in her hand, the sole survivor of a family destroyed by the creatures; she recovers speech only to scream the film's title. It features a female scientist who insists on entering the nest, soldiers who descend into tunnels with flamethrowers to rescue trapped children, and a climax in which the queens' egg chamber is incinerated. Newt, mute and clutching the severed head of her doll, is the girl of *Them!* reborn.

The difference lies in the allegorical valence. In the 1950s cycle the insect swarm figures the communist collective, faceless and implacable, much as Dostoevsky's Underground Man had used the anthill to figure a rationalized society without freedom. *Aliens* refuses the simple valence. Its most quoted moral judgment, delivered by Ripley after discovering Burke's treachery, is that she does not know which species is worse: "You don't see them fucking each other over for a goddamn percentage." Against the whole Cold War tradition, the film grants the hive a moral superiority over the human commercial order. Chapter 2 argues that this judgment reproduces, with its valence reversed, an argument Hobbes made in 1651 about bees and ants.

1.5 Cameron's authorship and the conjuncture of 1986

Cameron, born in Kapuskasing, Ontario, in 1954, trained in Roger Corman's New World Pictures as a model-maker, art director, and effects technician before directing *Piranha II: The Spawning* (1982). *The Terminator* (1984), written with the producer Gale Anne Hurd, established the formula he would refine: an implacable nonhuman antagonist, a corporate-technological system indifferent to human life, and a woman whose survival is bound to a child. Engaged by Hill and Giler, who had read the *Terminator* screenplay, Cameron drafted the *Aliens* treatment during the delay in *The Terminator*'s production, and in the same period wrote a draft of *Rambo: First Blood Part II*. The three projects are variations on a single problem: how an individual deprived of institutional protection can refound legitimate violence against a system that has abandoned her or him. Hurd produced *Aliens*, a distribution of authority unusual in the action cinema of the period, which complicates any reading of the film as the unmediated expression of masculine fantasy.

Cameron's maternal protagonists of 1984 and 1986 occupy opposite poles of the reproductive question. Sarah Connor is a generative mother: her significance lies in the son she will bear, and Constance Penley has shown how *The Terminator*'s time loop stages a primal scene in which the son sends back his own father (Penley 1986). Ripley is a preservative mother: her significance lies in a child she did not bear. Cameron's later work oscillates between these poles, a trajectory taken up in Chapter 7.

The conjuncture of 1986 sharpened every theme. *Top Gun* in May, *Aliens* in July, and *Platoon* in December mark Hollywood's divided reckoning with American military power: celebration, ambivalence, trauma. In January the space shuttle *Challenger* broke apart seventy-three seconds after launch, before a national television audience, killing all seven of its crew, among them Christa McAuliffe, the New Hampshire schoolteacher and mother of two whom NASA had chosen as its first teacher in space; in April Chernobyl made the runaway reactor a global image, although the film's climactic meltdown had been conceived and shot before it. Within months of the film's release, the Iran-Contra revelations exposed a privatized covert apparatus whose operators called it "the Enterprise." And in the same year the Baby M surrogacy dispute brought before a New Jersey court the question at the heart of the film: whether title to a child derives from biology, from contract, or from the child's preservation. Chapter 6 returns to that case.

CHAPTER 2

02

TWO LEVIATHANS

The Hive, the Company, and the Parasitology of Sovereignty

2.1 The frontispiece made resin

THE ENGRAVED FRONTISPIECE OF *Leviathan*, attributed to Abraham Bosse and executed under Hobbes's direction, is among the most analyzed images in the history of political thought. A crowned colossus rises over a landscape of town and countryside, sword in one hand and crosier in the other. Its torso and arms are composed of hundreds of small human figures turned inward toward the sovereign head. Above it runs a line from the Book of Job: *Non est potestas super terram quae comparetur ei*—there is no power on earth to be compared to him. The image visualizes Hobbes's central conceit, that the commonwealth is an artificial man composed of natural men, a single person made of a multitude through their authorization of one representative.

The nest beneath the atmosphere processor is that frontispiece rendered in resin. When the marines enter it, they find the colonists of Hadley's Hope embedded in the walls, their bodies incorporated into an architecture secreted by the warriors and organized around the reproductive center where the Queen presides. Incorporation, which in Hobbes remains a juridical metaphor, is here literal: the colonists have become the material substance of the sovereign's body. They are held not as subjects but as substrate, their function to host the sovereign's next generation, and each implantation kills its host: the creatures have taken the colony's people alive in order to use them up, and the only colonist the marines find alive and at liberty is a child. The

Queen, enthroned upon her ovipositor, is the crowned head toward which the incorporated bodies point.

Hobbes anticipated the objection that such a commonwealth might arise by nature. In chapter XVII of *Leviathan* he concedes that bees and ants live sociably with one another, which is why Aristotle numbered them among political creatures, and asks why mankind cannot do the same. His answers amount to a phenomenology of the Hive avant la lettre. Men compete for honor and dignity; these creatures do not. "Amongst these creatures the common good differeth not from the private." They lack the reason that finds fault with administration and the speech that represents good as evil. And, decisively, "the agreement of these creatures is natural; that of men is by covenant only, which is artificial." The Hive is the natural commonwealth Hobbes declared impossible for humans: a sovereign unity achieved without fear, covenant, or speech, and therefore without the possibility of sedition.

Ernst Kantorowicz's study of the king's two bodies supplies a second key (Kantorowicz 1957). Medieval and early modern jurists distinguished the mortal body natural of the king from the undying body politic of the crown. The Queen possesses two bodies in exactly this sense: her individual organism, and the reproductive apparatus—ovipositor, egg sac, incorporated hosts, brood—that constitutes the Hive's continuity. When Ripley incinerates the eggs and the ovipositor, she destroys the body politic. When the Queen tears herself free of her reproductive apparatus to pursue her, the sovereign separates her two bodies, abandoning the crown to avenge the dynasty. The climax expels the remaining body natural into the void. The film stages the death of a sovereign in both bodies, the outcome Kantorowicz's jurists designed their doctrine to prevent.

2.2 Worms in the entrails: the corporation as parasite

If the Hive is the natural Leviathan, the Company is the artificial Leviathan's internal disease. Hobbes devoted chapter XXII of *Leviathan* to "systems subject," among them the bodies politic chartered for the ordering of trade, and he was acerbic about merchant companies that sought to be sole buyers at home and sole sellers abroad. In chapter XXIX, cataloguing the infirmities that tend to dissolve a commonwealth, he named "the great number of corporations, which are as it were many lesser commonwealths in the bowels of a greater, like worms in the entrails of a natural man." The figure is extraordinary in the light of the franchise: a corporation imagined as a parasite gestating within the body politic, feeding upon it, and threatening to destroy it from inside.

The chestburster is Hobbes's worm, and the homology is strategic as well as visual. Burke carries out his plan in the medical laboratory. He releases two live facehuggers into the locked room where Ripley and Newt are sleeping and switches off the surveillance monitor so that no one will see, intending that both be implanted, frozen for the return voyage, and carried with their embryos past quarantine to the Company's bioweapons division. Implantation kills the host when the embryo emerges, so the plan is the attempted killing of a woman and a child for the Company's profit; in Ripley's reconstruction it also required sabotaging the marines' hypersleep units on the voyage home, so that no witness would survive. The corporation proposes to gestate inside a woman and a child exactly as Hobbes's corporation gestates within the commonwealth. It does not merely resemble the parasite; it seeks to become the parasite's host and master at once, what Chapter 7 calls the parasite of the parasite.

The chestburster is Hobbes's worm.

Weyland-Yutani descends historically from the chartered trading companies Hobbes knew—the East India Company, chartered in 1600, and the Virginia Company, chartered in 1606—which raised armies, administered territories, coined money, and made war. Philip Stern has described the East India Company as a company-state, a corporate sovereign in its own right (Stern 2011). The Colonial Marines, dispatched at the Company's initiative with a Company representative aboard, are the company-state's army in all but uniform. The corporation is also, juridically, a person. Medieval canonists described it as a *persona ficta*, and Hobbes defined the artificial person in chapter XVI as one whose words and actions represent another. A century before *Aliens*, the reporter's headnote to *Santa Clara County v. Southern Pacific Railroad* (1886) became the conventional citation for the doctrine that corporations are persons under the Fourteenth Amendment. The film's second artificial person, Bishop, contests that juridical monopoly (Chapter 5).

Marx supplies the corporation's physiology. "Capital is dead labour," he wrote, "that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (*Capital*, vol. 1, ch. 10). Vampire and parasitoid differ in one respect that matters here. The vampire draws off life; the parasitoid converts its host's body into the material of its own reproduction. Capital in Cameron's film is parasitoid rather than vampiric. It does not merely extract value from the colonists' labor; it converts their

bodies, and finally their reproductive capacity, into the means of its own expanded reproduction.

2.3 Species-being and the percentage

Ripley's judgment upon the species—that one does not see the creatures "fucking each other over for a goddamn percentage"—is the film's most explicit philosophical statement, and its obscenity is part of its sense: it is spoken as disgust, not as observation. Its grammar is comparative and its criterion is solidarity: it measures a species by whether its members sacrifice one another for private gain. It is, first, a gloss upon Hobbes's second difference between insects and men. Among bees the common good differs not from the private; among men, whose joy consists in comparing themselves with others, private good is pursued against the common. Ripley restates the point with its valence reversed. For Hobbes the coincidence of private and common good in the hive is a natural gift denied to men, who must therefore be governed by fear. For Ripley it is a moral reproach to the men who govern by contract.

It is, second, a gloss upon the young Marx. In the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts* of 1844, Marx, adapting Feuerbach, defines the human as a species-being (*Gattungswesen*), a creature that relates to its species as to a universal and produces freely in common. Estranged labor inverts this relation: it makes the life of the species a mere means to individual existence and estranges each human from every other. The xenomorphs, on this reading, are the unestranged species, every act of which serves the life of the kind. The humans of the Company are estranged precisely in Marx's sense, each pursuing a percentage at the species' expense. The title then names not the monsters but the condition of the humans. *Aliens* is a film about *Entfremdung*, and the creatures are its measure.

Mandeville would have recognized Burke. The *Fable* argues that private vices—avarice, vanity, fraud—aggregate into public prosperity, and the ideology of the terraforming venture is Mandevillean: a private appetite for a percentage is to issue in better worlds. Michel Serres's *The Parasite* gives that appetite its structural name (Serres 1982). For Serres the parasite is the one who eats at another's table without reciprocity, who interrupts a channel of exchange and takes a cut; beyond use value and exchange value, he proposes, lies the parasite's abuse value. Burke's percentage is abuse value. He interposes himself in every channel—between the Company and the colony, whose settlers he sends to the derelict; between the marines and their mission; between Ripley and the truth—and from each interruption he expects a cut. Serres also notes that the French *hôte* names both host and guest. The film exploits the same

ambiguity. Ripley, chosen by Burke to be a host in the parasitological sense, becomes instead a host in the hospitable one, sheltering the child he would have used.

2.4 "In the beginning all the world was America": terraforming as improvement

The colony of Hadley's Hope exists to manufacture an atmosphere. Its processors convert a hostile planetoid into a habitable one, and the corporate slogan the franchise attaches to Weyland-Yutani, "Building Better Worlds," states the project with Lockean candor. In the fifth chapter of the *Second Treatise* (1689), Locke grounds property in labor: whoever mixes labor with land and improves it encloses it from the common. Land left wholly to nature is, as he says, called waste, and his image of the colonial frontier—"in the beginning all the world was America"—makes the unimproved New World the type of a state of nature awaiting appropriation. Terraforming is improvement at planetary scale; LV-426 is America again.

Carl Schmitt would have recognized in the colony a *Landnahme*, the land appropriation he held to be the founding act of every legal order, the *nomos* of the earth (Schmitt 2003). The Hive is a rival *Landnahme*: it appropriates the processor itself, secreting its architecture into the machinery meant to make the planet human. Two nomoi contest one ground, and the film resolves the contest by annihilating the ground. Arendt, opening *The Human Condition* with the launch of Sputnik, diagnosed in the modern age a double alienation: from the world, as a durable human artifice, and from the earth, as the given home of the human condition (Arendt 1958). The colony embodies earth alienation in its purest form, a settlement whose very air is manufactured; the Company's indifference to the colonists embodies world alienation, for there is no shared world here, only a revenue stream.

The atmosphere processor is the film's most complex object. It is the machine in the garden, in Leo Marx's phrase (Marx 1964), the technological sublime of a frontier that manufactures its own nature; it is the seat of the Hive, which colonizes industrial modernity from within; and, damaged in the marines' first engagement, it becomes the thermonuclear device that obliterates the colony. Its interiors were filmed in a decommissioned London power station, so that a ruin of fossil modernity in the deindustrializing Britain of the mid-1980s served as the cradle of the Hive. The instrument of world-making becomes the instrument of world-ending. Heidegger described modern technology as an enframing that reveals everything, human beings included, as standing-reserve (Heidegger 1977). The processor completes that logic: the

colonists are first a labor reserve, then a reproductive reserve for the Hive, and finally fuel for an explosion that cancels the Company's liability.

2.5 Bare life, immunity, autoimmunity

Foucault distinguished the classical sovereign right to take life or let live from the modern biopolitical power to make live and let die, exercised over populations through the management of birth, health, and reproduction (Foucault 1978, 2003). The Company is a biopolitical actor in this precise sense. It does not kill the colonists; it lets them die, by sending them to the derelict and declining to warn them. Its interest in the organism is biopolitical through and through: the creature is valuable as a technology for administering death to populations, a bioweapon.

Giorgio Agamben's *homo sacer*, the life that may be killed without the killing counting as homicide or sacrifice, finds its cinematic image in the colonist the marines discover cocooned in the nest (Agamben 1998). She wakes, begs to be killed, and convulses as the embryo emerges; the marines incinerate her. Her death is neither murder nor execution nor sacrifice. It occurs in the zone of indistinction Agamben locates at the threshold of sovereign power, where life has been reduced to its biological minimum and stands outside any law. Agamben called the camp the hidden paradigm of modern political space; the nest is a camp for the production of hosts. Achille Mbembe's necropolitics, the subjugation of life to the power of death in colonial space, names the colony's status as a whole: a territory whose inhabitants are kept alive only so long as they remain profitable (Mbembe 2003).

Roberto Esposito's analysis of the immunitary paradigm illuminates the Company's ultimate plan (Esposito 2011). Immunization protects a community by introducing a controlled fragment of the threat it fears, as a vaccine does; pushed beyond a threshold, immunity turns against the body it protects and becomes autoimmune. The Company's pursuit of the organism is immunitary: it seeks to incorporate the most lethal life form known into its arsenal, protecting its interests by mastering the threat. Burke's plan to carry embryos inside human bodies past quarantine is immunization in its most literal and most perverse form, and the colony's fate is autoimmune: its life-support system becomes the bomb that destroys it.

Donna Haraway showed how the immunology of the 1980s figured the body as a militarized nation defending itself against a nonself (Haraway 1991), and Susan Sontag anatomized the military metaphors through which illness is narrated (Sontag 1978, 1989). The film's quarantine plot entered circulation in the early years of the AIDS epidemic, when that vocabulary of invasion, carriers, and quarantine was being turned

against people with AIDS, gay men above all. In March 1986 William F. Buckley Jr. proposed in *The New York Times* that everyone testing positive be tattooed (Buckley 1986); in November 1986 California voters rejected Proposition 64, an initiative promoted by Lyndon LaRouche's movement that would have brought people with AIDS under the state's quarantine and isolation laws. *Aliens* is an immunological fable, and its moral is Esposito's: a community that immunizes itself by incorporating the threat will be consumed by it.

CHAPTER 3

03

THE COLLAPSE OF THE ARMED COMMONWEALTH

Masculinity, Militarism, and the Vietnam Unconscious

3.1 The confiscated magazines

MAX WEBER DEFINED THE state as the human community that successfully claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory (Weber 1919). The marines enter the colony as the territorial instrument of that monopoly, and the film's first catastrophe is its paralysis. Because the nest lies beneath the processor's heat exchangers, where gunfire could rupture the cooling system and trigger a thermonuclear explosion, Lieutenant Gorman orders the marines' magazines collected before they advance. The state's violence is disarmed not by the enemy but by the infrastructure of the corporate colony it was sent to protect. The weapons that save the survivors are illegitimate ones—the magazines Vasquez and Drake conceal, the shotgun Hicks keeps—violence retained against command.

Gorman watches the ambush through helmet cameras on the monitors of the armored personnel carrier, a commander for whom war has become a screen. Paul Virilio's *War and Cinema*, published in French in 1984, argued that modern warfare had become a logistics of perception in which seeing and destroying converge (Virilio 1989). The production's decision to build the smartgun props around Steadicam support arms extends the homology of camera and weapon into the apparatus of the film itself. Gorman's paralysis is the paralysis of mediated command. Ripley breaks it by seizing the vehicle and driving it into the nest to extract the survivors, an act of practical

judgment against procedure in which a civilian woman literally takes the controls of the military machine.

Arendt described bureaucracy as the rule of Nobody, a tyranny without a tyrant in which no one can be held responsible (Arendt 1970). Gorman is that Nobody. He is not malicious; he is inexperienced, procedural, and absent, and the film punishes him less for cruelty than for the abdication of judgment. Arendt insisted, too, that power and violence are opposites: power is the human capacity to act in concert, violence its instrumental substitute. The marines possess violence without power, and once their implements fail they disintegrate. Ripley generates power in Arendt's sense. The survivors act in concert around her, and her authority derives from that concert rather than from rank.

3.2 Armor and flood

Klaus Theweleit's study of the memoirs and novels of the Freikorps—the right-wing paramilitaries who crushed the German revolutionary uprisings of 1918–1920, whose members murdered Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht in January 1919, and many of whom passed into the Nazi movement—read their fantasies as the psychic groundwork of fascism. It identified in the soldier male a body armored against dissolution, a self that defined its integrity by repelling everything fluid, soft, and engulfing—the flood, the swamp, the mire, and above all the feminine (Theweleit 1987–89). This dissertation borrows Theweleit's model of armored masculinity, not his diagnosis of fascism, for the marines. The xenomorph is the soldier male's nightmare in material form. It secretes and drools; its architecture is hardened slime; its blood is an acid that dissolves armor, decking, and flesh. The marines' armored bodies and the creatures' acid blood stage Theweleit's opposition with diagrammatic clarity, and the armor loses. Bodies are not so much penetrated as dissolved, absorbed, and incorporated into the resin of the nest.

Susan Jeffords read the action cinema of the Reagan years as the production of the "hard body," a muscular, impermeable masculinity offered as the restoration of a national body softened, in the period's rhetoric, by the Carter years and the defeat in Vietnam (Jeffords 1994). Private Hudson is the hard body as a performance of speech. His boasting before contact is an inventory of weapons and a declaration of invulnerability; his collapse after contact, compressed into the phrase "Game over," shows how far the hard body was always a rhetoric. Yvonne Tasker coined "musculinity" for the assumption of muscular signifiers by female performers (Tasker 1993). Vasquez is musculinity's emblem. Introduced doing pull-ups, she answers

Hudson's taunt about being mistaken for a man by asking whether he ever has been. Wounded and trapped in a duct, she and the despised Gorman kill themselves with a grenade rather than be taken alive as hosts, killing the creatures around them. It is the film's most complex image of martial solidarity: the most masculine woman and the least masculine man die together in a refusal of capture.

Ripley's relation to armor differs in kind. She does not harden her body; she improvises prostheses. She tapes a flamethrower to a pulse rifle, wears Hicks's locator, and finally enters the power loader, a cargo-handling exoskeleton she operates by trade. Claude Lévi-Strauss distinguished the engineer, who conceives tools for the purpose at hand, from the bricoleur, who makes do with whatever is available and repurposes the remains of earlier projects (Lévi-Strauss 1966). The marines are engineers whose purpose-built weapons fail; Ripley is a bricoleur. Her armor is assembled rather than embodied, and it serves, as Chapter 7 argues, not the defense of a self against the feminine but the defense of a child.

3.3 Vietnam as structuring absence

Cameron acknowledged the Vietnam analogy, and the film's tactical grammar confirms it: an expeditionary force of overwhelming technological superiority, contemptuous of an enemy it has never seen, ambushed in terrain the enemy has made its own. The creatures come out of the walls and ceilings as Viet Cong fighters emerged from tunnel systems, and Ripley's descent into the nest with a flamethrower reprises the figure of the tunnel rat. The atmosphere processor's destruction recalls the war's most notorious sentence. In February 1968, during the Tet Offensive, American artillery and air strikes destroyed much of the provincial town of Ben Tre, killing many of its civilians, to retake it from Viet Cong forces, and the Associated Press reporter Peter Arnett quoted an unnamed American major: it became necessary to destroy the town to save it. Ripley proposes the same logic in nuclear form—to "nuke the entire site from orbit"—and Burke opposes her on the ground that the installation carries a substantial dollar value; she overrules him by invoking the military chain of command, which now runs to Hicks, and Hicks backs the strike.

Jeffords has shown how American culture after Vietnam remasculinized the war, turning defeat into a narrative of betrayal by bureaucrats and redemption by individual warriors (Jeffords 1989). *Rambo: First Blood Part II*, which Cameron drafted, is the purest instance: its hero returns to Vietnam asking whether this time he gets to win. *Aliens* belongs to the same return narrative—Ripley goes back to LV-426 to win this time—and its demand for an unambiguous objective echoes the Weinberger principles

of 1984, which held that American forces should be committed only wholeheartedly and with the clear intention of winning. Yet the film diverts the remasculinizing narrative through a woman. Its returning warrior is a civilian mother, and its victory consists not in the recovery of prisoners or of honor but in the rescue of a child. The structure may be called a re-maternalization of the Vietnam return.

The cycle that followed sharpened the contrast. Oliver Stone's *Platoon*, released five months later, narrated the war as the loss of a moral father; Stanley Kubrick's *Full Metal Jacket* (1987) ended on the revelation that the sniper decimating the platoon was a teenage girl. The Vietnam film of the late 1980s repeatedly discovered a feminine figure at the heart of the enemy's violence. *Aliens* does so with a literalism no other film approaches: the enemy is a mother.

The enemy is a mother.

3.4 The captivity narrative and the racialized swarm

Richard Slotkin traced the American mythology of regeneration through violence to the Puritan captivity narrative, in which a colonial woman taken by Native captors endures trials, is redeemed, and returns (Slotkin 1973). The genre's founding text, Mary Rowlandson's narrative of 1682, bears a title that names this dissertation's theme: *The Sovereignty and Goodness of God*. John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956) secularized the form and exposed its pathology. Ethan Edwards searches for his niece Debbie, abducted in a Comanche raid led by the war chief Scar in which her family is killed, and for much of the film he intends to kill her because she has become one of Scar's wives: his racism counts her as lost to whiteness. *Aliens* reprises the structure. Newt is captured by the creatures and carried to their nest; Ripley pursues her and retrieves her at the threshold of irreversible contamination, as the egg before her opens. The fear of the child's becoming-other, which *Alien 3* will make explicit in an autopsy, is the captivity narrative's fear of miscegenation transposed into parasitology.

The racial logic of the genre persists in the bestiary. Frantz Fanon observed that the settler describes the colonized in a zoological language—reptilian motion, stench, "breeding swarms"—and that this language licenses violence (Fanon 1963). John Dower's *War Without Mercy*, published in 1986, documented how American wartime propaganda figured the Japanese as insects and vermin to be exterminated (Dower

1986). The marines' name for their mission, a bug hunt, inherits this lexicon; the enemy is dark, faceless, swarming, and defined by an uncontrollable fecundity. James Tiptree Jr.'s "The Screwfly Solution" (1977), published under the name Raccoona Sheldon, had already inverted the procedure: an alien agency clears the earth of humanity by a technique modeled on agricultural pest control, treating humans as humans treat insects. *Aliens* does not perform Tiptree's inversion.

The racial composition of the survivors completes the indictment. The Colonial Marines are presented as a multiracial collective. Sergeant Apone and Private Frost are Black; Vasquez is written as Latina, though she is played by Jenette Goldstein, a white Jewish American actress, so that the unit's most visible Latina identity is performed across ethnicity rather than cast from it. The film destroys that collective. The commonwealth that survives into hypersleep consists of a white woman, a white girl, a white man, and a white-coded android. The preservative order is founded on the ruins of the integrated military of the 1980s, and it reconstitutes something visually indistinguishable from the white settler family at the center of the captivity narrative. Any account of the film's feminism or humanism that fails to register this fact remains partial; Chapter 7 counts it among the aporias of preservation.

3.5 Hicks and the unhegemonic masculine

R. W. Connell's analysis of hegemonic masculinity—the culturally exalted form against which subordinate and complicit masculinities are defined—helps specify what Corporal Hicks represents (Connell 1995). Hicks is competent without bravado, calm under fire, and willing to cede command to the person best placed to exercise it. His intimacy with Ripley is conducted entirely through instruments of preservation. He teaches her the pulse rifle and its grenade launcher, in a scene that substitutes a technical apprenticeship for a seduction; he gives her a locator so that he can find her; he offers his first name. Wounded by acid, he becomes the one who is carried.

The relation has the structure Aristotle assigned to friendship of virtue, in which each wishes good to the other for the other's sake (*Nicomachean Ethics* VIII–IX), and it is notable for what it omits. There is no consummation, and the film's closing family is founded on comradeship rather than conjugality. Hicks is the masculine as it can exist inside the preservative regime: protective, but not proprietary.

CHAPTER 4

04

MOTHERS AT WAR

Feminist Theory and the Maternal Antagonism

4.1 From the gaze to the Final Girl to the monstrous-feminine

FEMINIST FILM THEORY ENTERED the 1980s with Laura Mulvey's argument that classical narrative cinema divides labor between an active male looker and a passive female image whose to-be-looked-at-ness structures the spectacle (Mulvey 1975). *Alien* had honored that division in one notorious scene, in which Ripley undresses before the hidden creature's final attack. *Aliens* refuses it. Ripley is seldom displayed; she is the bearer of the look—watching the monitors, reading the colony's records, examining specimens in the laboratory. Her authority is epistemic before it is martial. She sees what the men cannot, and the film is organized around the slow alignment of others' perception with hers.

Linda Williams argued that when the woman looks in the horror film, she often recognizes in the monster a figure of her own marginality, a shared status as biological threat to masculine power (Williams 1984). That recognition becomes literal in the egg chamber. Carol Clover's Final Girl—the boyishly named, competent, sexually reticent survivor of the slasher film—fits the Ripley of *Alien* closely enough that Clover discussed her (Clover 1992). In *Aliens* the figure mutates. The Final Girl survives; Ripley preserves. Her narrative function is no longer to outlast the monster but to keep another alive, and the Final Girl becomes a Final Mother.

Joanna Russ had argued in 1972 that Western narrative supplies women with almost no plots beyond the love story and the victim's ordeal, and that a woman slotted

into a conventional heroic plot reads as a man in disguise (Russ 1972). Ripley's plot is neither love story nor ordeal. It is the rescue, whose canonical bearers—Perseus freeing Andromeda, Saint George delivering the princess from the dragon—are male. The film transfers the rescue to a woman and makes the rescued a girl, reorganizing the iconography of the dragon-slayer along a matrilineal axis.

Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection supplies the deeper structure (Kristeva 1982). The abject is what disturbs identity, system, and order—bodily fluids, the corpse, the border between inside and outside—and the primary abject is the maternal body from which the infant must separate to become a subject. Barbara Creed built on Kristeva to define the monstrous-feminine, arguing that horror's monsters repeatedly figure the archaic mother, the parthenogenetic origin prior to paternal law who threatens to reabsorb what she bore (Creed 1986, 1993). *Aliens* incarnates the archaic mother with unprecedented literalism. The nest is a womb secreted over the machinery of the colony—humid, dark, ribbed, lined with bodies—and its sovereign is a mother who bears without mate, whose fecundity is limitless, and whose relation to her offspring is total.

4.2 The co-optation thesis and the evidence of the two cuts

The most rigorous feminist critique of *Aliens* holds that it co-opts feminist energies into patriarchal form. Janice Hocker Rushing, reading the *Alien* films through Erich Neumann's Jungian typology of the Great Mother, argued that *Aliens* splits the feminine archetype into a Good Mother and a Terrible Mother and enlists the first to destroy the second, so that a woman's power is licensed only as it annihilates the archaic feminine on behalf of a patriarchal frontier myth (Rushing 1989; Neumann 1955). Mary Ann Doane read the film's obsessive maternalism as a symptom of anxieties provoked by new reproductive technologies, which had unsettled the assumption that maternity, unlike paternity, was self-evident (Doane 1990). On these readings Ripley's heroism is the price of her domestication.

The co-optation thesis is strongest where the film is most explicit, and the two cuts illuminate the point. In the Special Edition, Ripley learns at Gateway that her daughter died during her drift. Her attachment to Newt is thereby motivated as substitution and reparation: maternity is presupposed, biological, and lost, and the film becomes a narrative of its recovery. In the theatrical cut, which omitted the scene, Ripley has no announced child. Her bond with Newt arises without precedent, an elective attachment to a stranger's orphan. A studio's editorial economy thus produced, in the version most audiences saw in 1986, the more radical text: a maternity without biological

antecedent. The variance between the cuts records the film's hesitation between two grounds of motherhood, generation and preservation, and it is the earliest evidence for the thesis of this dissertation.

On one point the cuts agree, and the co-optation critique needs it. In *Alien* the facehugger's rape was inflicted on a man. In *Aliens* the same violation is aimed, deliberately and by a human being, at a woman and at a child: Burke releases the facehuggers on Ripley and Newt. The sequel returns the franchise's founding image of sexual violation to female bodies and directs it at a girl, restoring the gendering of threat that the first film had overturned, and it is this threat, more than any choice of Ripley's, that makes her violence maternal.

Elizabeth Hills, drawing on Deleuzian becoming, questioned whether active heroines must be read either as figurative males or as mothers in disguise (Hills 1999). Her intervention points beyond the co-optation debate. The question is not whether Ripley's maternity domesticates her violence, but whether maternity itself, as the film reconstructs it, remains the institution the critique presupposes.

4.3 Women's time: Vasquez, the Queen, Ripley

Kristeva's "Women's Time" distinguished generations, or attitudes, within feminism (Kristeva 1981). A first sought insertion into the linear time of history and politics on equal terms with men. A second, emerging after 1968, refused that time, affirming a radical difference associated with the cyclical time of repetition and the monumental time of the species. Kristeva called for a third attitude in which the opposition between masculine and feminine as rival metaphysical entities would itself be interiorized and dissolved.

The film distributes these attitudes among its women with schematic clarity. Vasquez is the first: insertion into the masculine military order on its own terms, measured by strength, aggression, and equality of risk. The Queen is the second rendered monstrous: pure difference, absorbed in the cyclical time of reproduction and the monumental time of a species without history. Ripley occupies the third position, and the film grounds it in her temporal dislocation. Her fifty-seven years of drift have removed her from linear time altogether; she wakes into a future that has consumed her past, her career, and, in the Special Edition, her daughter's entire life. Hamlet's complaint that the time is out of joint is her condition. The film begins with Ripley preserved in hypersleep and ends with four bodies preserved in hypersleep. Her time is neither linear nor cyclical but suspended: the time of preservation itself.

4.4 Becoming-mother: from Wollstonecraft to Ruddick

The humanist origin of the feminist tradition is Mary Wollstonecraft's *Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792), which grounded women's claims in their possession of reason. The film's opening act tests that claim. Before the Company's inquiry, Ripley gives an accurate account of the creature and is disbelieved; her license is revoked and she is reduced to work on the cargo docks. Miranda Fricker's concept of testimonial injustice—a speaker receiving deflated credibility owing to prejudice—describes the scene precisely (Fricker 2007), and Christa Wolf's *Cassandra* (1983) had just retold the myth of the prophetess fated to speak truly and be disbelieved (Wolf 1984). Sandra Harding's *The Science Question in Feminism*, published the year of the film, argued that the knowledge of those marginalized by an institution can be epistemically privileged (Harding 1986). Ripley's standpoint is that of the sole survivor, and the film vindicates it.

Simone de Beauvoir's analysis of maternity in *The Second Sex* (1949) is the necessary counterweight to any celebration of the maternal. For Beauvoir, maternity confines woman to immanence, the repetitive reproduction of life, while man achieves transcendence through projects that remake the world; motherhood acquires value only when freely assumed. Her most famous sentence—"One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman"—admits a precise détournement: one is not born, but rather becomes, a mother. Ripley's maternity is not immanence but project. It is chosen, achieved, and exercised through action that transforms a world.

Shulamith Firestone located the root of women's oppression in the biological family and proposed liberation through technology, including artificial reproduction (Firestone 1970). *Aliens* stages the dystopian obverse of her program: reproduction severed from the female body, but captured by capital, which proposes to use women as incubators for its product. Adrienne Rich distinguished motherhood as experience—the relation of a woman to her reproductive powers and to children—from motherhood as institution, the apparatus that keeps that relation under male control (Rich 1976). The Queen embodies the institution hypostatized: she is chained to her ovipositor, captive of her own reproductive function, a sovereign who is also the prisoner of her office. Ripley embodies the experience freed from the institution, a maternity unregulated by marriage, law, or biology.

Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* supplies the concept the film most needs (Ruddick 1980, 1989). Maternal practice, Ruddick argued, answers three demands: preservation, growth, and social acceptability. The first and most fundamental is preservation, and the virtue it calls forth she named preservative love. Two features of

her account are decisive. Mothering is a practice rather than a biological status, open to anyone—men included—who takes up its demands. And maternal thinking, she hoped, could ground a politics of peace, since a practice organized around keeping fragile lives alive stands in principle against war. *Aliens* confirms the first claim and strains the second. Hicks and Bishop become maternal thinkers in Ruddick's sense, practitioners of preservative love; but the film militarizes preservation, arming it with flamethrower and exoskeleton. Ruddick acknowledged that mothers have often been complicit in militarism. Ripley shows preservative love becoming a casus belli.

Nancy Chodorow's account of the reproduction of mothering, in which daughters acquire the capacity to mother through identification with their mothers, has a small but exact correlate in Newt's relation to her doll, Casey, whom she mothers as she is mothered (Chodorow 1978). Carol Gilligan's ethics of care and Nel Noddings's account of caring as a relation completed in the cared-for (Gilligan 1982; Noddings 1984) describe the ethical texture of the bond between Ripley and Newt—its partiality, proximity, and responsiveness—and, as section 4.7 shows, its limit.

4.5 Demeter's torches: matricide, splitting, and the transitional object

The rescue of Newt reenacts the oldest Western myth of a mother's search for an abducted daughter. In the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, Persephone is seized by the lord of the underworld; Demeter wanders for nine days with blazing torches in her hands; the earth goes barren in her grief; and Persephone, having eaten a pomegranate seed below, is bound to return there for part of each year. The colony's world is named Acheron, after a river of the underworld, in the film's expanded nomenclature. Ripley descends into it bearing fire—a flamethrower is a torch—to retrieve a girl taken below, and arrives as the seed of the underworld is about to be planted in her. Adrienne Rich read the myth as the expression of every daughter's longing for a mother whose love and power could undo violation and bring her back from death (Rich 1976). That is Ripley's narrative function exactly, and the doubled daughter of the Special Edition sharpens it: Amanda is the Persephone not recovered, Newt the Persephone restored.

Luce Irigaray argued that Western culture is founded not, as Freud proposed in *Totem and Taboo*, on the murder of the father but on the murder of the mother, and she read the *Oresteia* as its charter: Orestes kills Clytemnestra, and the new court of Athens acquits him (Irigaray 1993). She also called for restoring the mother–daughter genealogy that the abduction of Kore had severed (Irigaray 1994). *Aliens* both enacts and complicates her thesis. Its order is founded on a matricide, the killing of the Queen;

but the matricide is performed by a mother on behalf of a daughter, so that a female genealogy is restored by destroying a rival maternal sovereign. The film invents a matrilineal matricide.

The film invents a matrilineal matricide.

The *Oresteia* offers a further key, which the franchise's biology makes startling. At Orestes' trial, Apollo argues that the mother is no true parent of the child but only the nurse of the seed planted in her, the father alone being the parent (*Eumenides* 657–66). Aristotle systematized the claim in the *Generation of Animals*, assigning form to the male and mere matter to the female. The xenomorph's life cycle is Apollo's embryology literalized: the host, of either sex, contributes nothing but nourishment to an embryo implanted from outside. Burke's plan treats Ripley and Newt as Apollonian mothers in exactly this sense. The Queen, by contrast, is the mother of Johann Jakob Bachofen's *Das Mutterrecht* (1861), the chthonic sovereign of a stage of human history that Bachofen imagined as preceding father-right and figured through images of swamp fecundity. Friedrich Engels, drawing on Bachofen, called the overthrow of mother-right "the world historical defeat of the female sex" (Engels 1884). *Aliens* restages the sequence in reverse. Father-right (Apone, Gorman), the state (the marines), and private property (the Company) collapse in succession, and two forms of mother-right confront one another across the ruins: the chthonic and the prosthetic.

Melanie Klein supplies the psychic grammar of that confrontation. In the paranoid-schizoid position the infant splits the mother into a wholly good and a wholly bad object, projecting its destructive impulses onto the latter; in the depressive position the two are recognized as one person, and ambivalence is borne (Klein 1946). *Aliens* is a paranoid-schizoid film. It splits the maternal into Ripley and the Queen with absolute rigidity, and its climax enacts the destruction of the bad object by the good. The franchise reaches the depressive position only by dismembering its heroine: in *Alien 3* Ripley carries a Queen embryo, and in *Alien Resurrection* she is a clone bearing the creature's genome.

D. W. Winnicott described the good-enough mother as one who provides a holding environment while gradually failing the infant's omnipotent demands, and identified the transitional object—the blanket, the doll—as the first not-me possession through which a child negotiates the space between inner and outer worlds (Winnicott 1953). Newt's transitional object is the severed head of a doll. When Newt is taken, Ripley

finds only that head floating in the flooded passage: the transitional object marks the absent child. Freud read Medusa's severed head as an image of castration that petrifies and protects at once; Hélène Cixous answered that one need only look at Medusa straight on to see that she is not deadly but laughing (Freud 1940; Cixous 1976). The Queen's crested head, which Ripley must look at directly, sits between these readings: the monstrous-feminine as petrifying threat, and as the face of a mother.

4.6 The comparative archive

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is the founding feminist text on the male usurpation of generation, and Ellen Moers read it as a birth myth shadowed by its author's experience of maternal death and infant loss (Moers 1976). Victor Frankenstein is, in this dissertation's terms, the anti-preserver: he generates a life and abandons it at birth. His most consequential act is reproductive annihilation. Having begun a female companion for his creature, he tears her apart, fearing that "a race of devils would be propagated upon the earth." Ripley's incineration of the eggs repeats Victor's gesture on behalf of the same species.

Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915) imagines a parthenogenetic society of women in which motherhood is the organizing principle of politics and religion. The Hive is Herland's nightmare double: a parthenogenetic polity in which motherhood is the whole of politics, and in which the eugenic logic Gilman's utopia shares with the sociobiology of the 1970s is carried to its terminus. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) contains a sentence that could stand as an epigraph to the Queen: "The king was pregnant." Le Guin's ambisexual Gethenians decouple sovereignty from fixed sex; the Hive fuses sovereignty and gestation absolutely.

Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985), published a year before the film, imagines a theocratic state that enslaves fertile women as handmaids and subjects them to ritualized rape by the Commanders of the ruling class, so that they bear children for those households. Burke's plan is Gilead's policy without Gilead's theology: the Company would use Ripley and Newt as vessels for its product, at the cost of their lives. Both texts emerge from a conjuncture in which reproductive capacity had become an explicit object of political contest, and Gerda Lerner's *The Creation of Patriarchy* (1986) traced that contest to its origins, arguing that the appropriation of women's sexual and reproductive capacity preceded and underlay the formation of private property (Lerner 1986). Silvia Federici later located the same appropriation at the origin of capitalism (Federici 2004).

Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time* (1976) offers the utopian form of preservative kinship. In Piercy's future, children gestate in artificial brooders and are raised by three comothers of any sex; men nurse. Motherhood is a practice severed from biology and distributed among chosen persons. Piercy's protagonist, confined in a psychiatric hospital, finally poisons the doctors whose experiments threaten that future, an act of violence undertaken to preserve a future she will not inhabit. Ripley's violence has the same structure. Joanna Russ's *The Female Man* (1975), with its assassin Jael, had already made feminist violence a subject of speculative fiction; Ripley's is distinguished by its object, which is not a man but a rival mother.

Octavia E. Butler's "Bloodchild" (1984) is the archive's most searching counter-text. On a distant world, human refugees live under the protection of the Tlic, an insectile species that implants its eggs in human hosts, usually young men, and removes the grubs before they devour their bearers. The humans live on what Butler calls the Preserve. Butler's Preserve is protection and captivity at once; its preservers are also its masters; and the relation between Gan and the Tlic T'Gatoi is negotiated, intimate, and ambivalent, an interspecies kinship founded on reproduction under unequal power. Butler's *Dawn* (1987) extends the problem: the Oankali preserve humanity after a nuclear war at the price of genetic exchange, and Lilith Iyapo becomes mother to a hybrid future. Butler shows what Cameron cannot. Preservation founds dominion, and the preserver's dominion can become ownership. Chapter 7 makes this the first aporia of preservative sovereignty.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986), drawing on Elizabeth Fisher's anthropology, proposed that the first cultural device was probably not a weapon but a container—a sling, a bag, a basket—and that the hero's story of spear and kill had displaced the older story of gathering and carrying (Le Guin 1989). The film's defining image combines both. Ripley emerges from the nest with Newt held against her in one arm and the taped flamethrower and rifle in the other; the carrier bag and the spear are fused in a single body. Donna Haraway's manifesto for cyborgs, published in 1985 while the film was in production, closed with the declaration "I would rather be a cyborg than a goddess" (Haraway 1985). The climax of *Aliens* stages that sentence as combat. In the power loader Ripley is the cyborg; the Queen, archaic mother of a chthonic order, is the goddess; and the cyborg wins.

4.7 The egg-chamber truce

The film's moral center lies in a scene of perhaps two minutes. Having found Newt, Ripley flees through the nest and stumbles into the egg chamber, where the Queen presides over her ovipositor and her brood. Warriors advance. Ripley raises the flamethrower over the eggs. The Queen, with a movement of her head and a hiss, sends the warriors back. A negotiation has occurred without language: two mothers, each with a child to protect, have recognized one another and arrived at a truce. Ripley begins to withdraw. Then an egg beside her opens. She burns the eggs, the ovipositor, and the chamber, and runs, the Queen's scream behind her.

The scene admits at least five readings, and the dissertation holds them together. In Hegelian terms, it is a struggle for recognition in which two self-consciousnesses face one another under the threat of death and achieve a momentary mutual acknowledgment (Hegel 1807); Ripley then annuls it. In Levinasian terms, it is the only moment in which the Queen has a face, the face Levinas described as the epiphany of the other that forbids killing (Levinas 1969). In an interview conducted in 1986, Levinas was asked whether an animal has a face; he allowed that one cannot entirely refuse it to an animal, and confessed that he did not know whether a snake has one (Levinas 1988). The film's answer is that the xenomorph has a face exactly once.

In Hobbesian terms, the truce is a covenant made under fear in the state of nature, and Hobbes held such covenants binding (*Leviathan* XIV). He also held that a covenant of mutual trust in that condition becomes void upon any reasonable suspicion that the other party will not perform. The opening egg is that suspicion, and Ripley's breach is, on Hobbes's terms, licit. In the terms of care ethics, the scene displays care's partiality: Noddings bounded obligation by the possibility of completing a caring relation, and the Queen's brood lies outside Ripley's circle. In Ruddick's terms, it is preservative love preserving its own at the cost of another's.

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) supplies the most unsettling reading. Benjamin distinguished law-preserving from law-making violence, and both from a divine violence that destroys the legal order itself. His paradigm of mythic, law-making violence is the slaughter of Niobe's children by Apollo and Artemis, punishment for a mother's boast of her fecundity (Benjamin 1978). The Queen is Niobe, and the burning of her brood is mythic violence: an act that founds a new order—Ripley's—in blood, and leaves its victim, like Niobe, a monument of grief. The egg-chamber scene therefore reveals the founding violence of preservative sovereignty. Like every founding, Ripley's begins with a breach.

CHAPTER 5

05

ARTIFICIAL PERSONS

Humanism, Its Limits, and the Ethics of the Synthetic

5.1 The humanist inheritance

RENAISSANCE HUMANISM DEFINED the human by the absence of a fixed nature. In Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (composed 1486), God tells Adam that he has been made neither heavenly nor earthly, neither mortal nor immortal, so that he may fashion himself in whatever form he prefers. Ripley's trajectory—warrant officer, disbelieved witness, dock laborer, consultant, commander, mother—is Pico's self-fashioning under duress. Michel de Montaigne's "Of Cannibals" (1580) supplied humanism's critical counter-tradition, relativizing the category of the barbarian and finding more barbarity in eating a man alive than in eating him dead. The xenomorph literally eats its host alive from within; the Company eats the colonists alive economically; and Ripley's comparison of the species is Montaigne's inversion of savage and civilized carried into biology.

Kant gave humanism its moral law. In the *Groundwork* (1785) he commanded that humanity, in oneself and in every other, be treated always as an end and never merely as a means, and he distinguished price, which admits an equivalent, from dignity, which does not. The Company is the systematic denial of the formula of humanity. Its directive in *Alien* rendered the crew expendable; its representative in *Aliens* treats colonists, marines, a woman, and a child as means to a product. Burke's percentage is the conversion of dignity into price.

Twentieth-century humanism reformulated these claims under the shadow of catastrophe. Jean-Paul Sartre's lecture "Existentialism Is a Humanism" (1946) held that existence precedes essence and that each person, in choosing, legislates for all; *Being and Nothingness* (1943) named the evasion of that freedom bad faith. Gorman, sheltering behind procedure, and Burke, behind policy, are studies in bad faith. Albert Camus's *The Plague* (1947) is the closest humanist analogue to the film's collective action: a town besieged by an inhuman scourge, resisted not by heroes but by people doing their work with decency, under no illusion that the bacillus can ever be finally destroyed. *The Rebel* (1951) condensed Camus's ethic into a formula—"I rebel—therefore we exist." Ripley's refusal of the Company founds a "we."

Frantz Fanon and Aimé Césaire indicted European humanism as the ideology of a civilization that spoke incessantly of Man while massacring men, and called for a new humanism forged by the colonized (Fanon 1963; Césaire 1972). Sylvia Wynter later argued that the Western figure of Man overrepresents one genre of the human as if it were the human itself (Wynter 2003). These critiques do not dismiss the film's humanism; they require us to ask which humans it preserves.

5.2 Bishop: the automaton, the First Law, and the anti-Bartleby

Leviathan opens not with the state of nature but with the automaton. Since life is but a motion of limbs, Hobbes asks, "why may we not say that all automata (engines that move themselves by springs and wheels as doth a watch) have an artificial life?" The commonwealth is introduced as an artificial man made in imitation of the natural one, of greater stature and strength, "for whose protection and defence it was intended." Hobbes's political philosophy thus begins with an android whose purpose is protection. In chapter XVI he defines the person: one whose words and actions are his own is a natural person; one whose words and actions represent another's is a feigned or artificial person.

Bishop, the synthetic officer attached to the marines, introduces himself by saying that he prefers the term "artificial person." The phrase is Hobbes's, and the film sets it against its other artificial person, the corporation. Ash, Bishop's predecessor in *Alien*, was the artificial person as the Company's instrument. Bishop is the artificial person as the commonwealth's protector, the automaton of Hobbes's introduction, made for protection and defence. The film's two artificial persons stand to one another as the parasitic corporation of chapter XXIX stands to the protective artificial man of the introduction.

Bishop explains to the hostile Ripley that behavioral inhibitors make it impossible for him to harm a human being or, by omission of action, allow one to be harmed. The formulation paraphrases the First Law of Robotics in Isaac Asimov's "Runaround" (1942), and Asimov's First Law is a law of preservation. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the language the word *robot* from the Czech for forced labor, had already defined the artificial person as the worker who does what others will not. Bishop is that worker. When someone must crawl through a narrow conduit to the colony's transmitter to summon the second drop ship, he volunteers, observing that he is the only one qualified, that he would prefer not to, and that though synthetic he is not stupid.

"I would prefer not to" is the formula of Herman Melville's scrivener Bartleby (1853), whose passive refusal Gilles Deleuze and Giorgio Agamben read as pure potentiality, a suspension of all willing (Deleuze 1997; Agamben 1999). Bishop inverts Bartleby: he prefers not to, and goes. In doing so he becomes the purest Kantian moral agent in the film. Kant held that an action has genuine moral worth only when performed from duty, and that this worth is most evident when inclination opposes it (*Groundwork* I). Bishop's preference is inclination; his crawl through the conduit is duty; and the gap between them, which a mere program would not register, is where his moral personality appears. The later scenes complete the portrait. Torn in half by the Queen, his upper body still reaches out with one hand to catch Newt as she slides toward the open airlock.

Alan Turing proposed in 1950 that the question whether machines can think be replaced by an imitation game (Turing 1950). Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), and Ridley Scott's adaptation *Blade Runner* (1982), replaced the test of intelligence with a test of empathy. Bishop passes the empathy test that Burke fails. And the film ends with Dick's question displaced onto its humans: Newt asks whether she will be able to dream in hypersleep, and Ripley answers that she thinks they both can.

5.3 Burke, or the Foole

Before agreeing to return to LV-426, Ripley exacts from Burke a promise that the expedition will destroy the creatures rather than study or retrieve them, and he gives his word. Hobbes devoted a famous passage of *Leviathan* XV to the Foole, who "hath said in his heart, there is no such thing as justice," and who reasons that breaking a covenant may be rational when it conduces to his benefit. Hobbes's reply is that the covenant-breaker "cannot be received into any society that unite themselves for peace and defence but by the error of them that receive him," and that, cast out, he cannot survive. Burke is the Foole in exact detail. He breaks his covenant and tries to have Ripley and Newt implanted, which would have killed them, for the Company's profit. When Ripley exposes him, Hicks proposes executing him on the spot—"I say we grease this rat-fuck son of a bitch right now"—and only the creatures' cutting of the colony's power interrupts the reckoning. During the siege Burke seals a door against his companions to save himself, and one of the creatures kills him on the other side. The film executes Hobbes's sentence: the covenant-breaker, excluded from the society of mutual defense, perishes.

Burke is not a monster in the film's idiom but a businessman, the affable young professional of mid-1980s American social discourse, and his evil is managerial. Arendt's account of the banality of evil—Eichmann's incapacity to think from another's standpoint and his reliance on the clichés of his office—describes him well (Arendt 1963). He justifies the colony's fate in the language of judgment calls and acceptable risk. Kant's concept of radical evil, the propensity to subordinate the moral law to the incentive of self-love, names the structure of his choices (Kant 1793). Weber ended his account of capitalism's iron cage with the image of "specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart" (Weber 1930); Burke is the specialist without spirit. Against such an adversary, the film's humanism is not the affirmation of a species but a judgment about conduct.

5.4 Anti-humanism, posthumanism, and the cyborg in the loader

Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1947) charged humanism with remaining within metaphysics, defining the human as a rational animal and so failing to think its essence (Heidegger 1993). Foucault ended *The Order of Things* (1966) by suggesting that man is a recent invention, likely to be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea (Foucault 1970). Posthumanism inherited these critiques while affirming the entanglements of human with machine, animal, and information that anti-humanism had disclosed. N. Katherine Hayles traced how cybernetics imagined information without a body (Hayles 1999); Rosi Braidotti proposed an ethics centered on *zoe*, the generative force of life that exceeds the human (Braidotti 2013); Cary Wolfe defined posthumanism as a decentering of the human that remains attentive to embodiment (Wolfe 2010).

Aliens answers each of these positions with a body. Against Hayles's disembodied information it sets Bishop, whose intelligence survives bisection but whose care is expressed through the one hand that can still reach. Against Braidotti's affirmation of *zoe* it sets the Queen, who is *zoe* embodied and whom the film destroys. Here the film's humanism reaches its limit, for the ethics Braidotti proposes would require it to ask what the extermination of the Hive costs. And with Haraway it sets Ripley in the power loader, a cyborg whose capacity to act is constituted by her coupling with a machine.

5.5 Two inhumans

Jean-François Lyotard's *The Inhuman* (1988) distinguished two inhumanities (Lyotard 1991). The first is the system: development, techno-science, and capital, a process indifferent to human beings that pursues its own complexification and dreams of surviving the death of the sun by detaching thought from the body. The second is infancy: the *infans*, the one not yet speaking, the undetermined being whom every adult carries as an unpaid debt to childhood. Lyotard asked what else remains to resist the first inhumanity than the second.

The film enacts his question. The Company is the inhuman system, colonizing the planets and seeking a weapon. Newt, when found, is mute—*infans* in the literal sense—having survived alone in the ducts after her community was consumed. She recovers speech with Ripley, and the recovery of her name is her return to the human world. Ripley's alliance with the mute child against the Company is the alliance Lyotard prescribed: the inhumanity of infancy set against the inhumanity of the system. His essay "Can Thought Go On Without a Body?" imagined techno-science

seeking hardware for a thought that could outlast the solar catastrophe. Bishop is the film's answer: thought that goes on in a broken body, and spends its last strength holding a child.

5.6 The human as verdict

Richard Ryder coined "speciesism" in 1970, and Peter Singer gave it philosophical currency in *Animal Liberation* (1975), arguing that species membership is as arbitrary a ground for moral discrimination as race or sex. Jacques Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* located the founding of the human subject in a sacrificial disavowal of the animal's gaze (Derrida 2008). *Aliens* is speciesist in its action and anti-speciesist in its judgments. It exterminates the Hive without mourning; yet its explicit moral comparison ranks the Hive above the Company, and its moral exemplar is a machine.

The resolution lies in a single line. After Ripley has expelled the Queen, the bisected Bishop looks up at her and pronounces, "Not bad for a human." The evaluator is the artificial person; the human is the evaluated. Humanity appears in the film not as a species property but as a verdict, a judgment passed on conduct, which an android can earn and a corporate executive can forfeit. The criterion of the verdict is preservation. Bishop preserves; Hicks preserves; Ripley preserves; Burke preys. The film's humanism is therefore neither species humanism nor posthumanism but a *preservative humanism*: the human is whoever keeps the vulnerable alive. Its limit is equally clear. The Queen preserves her own, and the film refuses her the verdict, because her preservation requires the consumption of others. Whether Ripley's preservation escapes the same objection is the question Chapter 7 cannot avoid.

Humanity appears in the film not as a species property but as a verdict.

CHAPTER 6

06

NATALITY UNDER FIRE

Dominion, the Newcomer, and the Child

6.1 Dominion in the mother: Leviathan XX and the sexual contract

CHAPTER XX OF *Leviathan*, on paternal and despotical dominion, contains a doctrine as radical as anything in early modern political thought, and one largely absent from Hobbes's reception until feminist scholarship recovered it. Dominion over a child, Hobbes argues, is not acquired by generation, "as if therefore the parent had dominion over his child because he begat him," but by the child's consent, express or declared by other sufficient arguments. In the condition of mere nature, where there are no matrimonial laws, the father cannot be known unless the mother declares him, and therefore "the dominion is in the mother." Since the infant is first in the mother's power, so that she may nourish or expose it, it owes its life to her if she nourishes it; but if she exposes it and another nourishes it, dominion passes to that other, "for it ought to obey him by whom it is preserved; because preservation of life being the end for which one man becomes subject to another, every man is supposed to promise obedience to him in whose power it is to save or destroy him."

Three consequences follow. Hobbes severs dominion from generation: begetting confers no title. He locates the original dominion of the state of nature in the mother rather than the father, against the patriarchalism that Robert Filmer would elaborate in *Patriarcha* and Locke would refute. And he grounds dominion finally in preservation: the child obeys whoever keeps it alive. Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* asked how, if Hobbes's state of nature makes mothers lords, women came to be subordinated in

civil society, and answered that the social contract presupposes a prior sexual contract—a conquest and a conjugal subjection that the canonical theory conceals (Pateman 1988).

Aliens reverses Pateman's sequence. The patriarchal and conjugal orders collapse: in the Special Edition Newt's father is the colony's first host; her mother dies; the marines' fathers of command, Apone and Gorman, are killed or disgraced; the Company betrays every covenant. The state of nature returns on LV-426, and with it Hobbes's original allocation of dominion. Ripley acquires dominion over Newt neither by generation, which she lacks, nor by contract, which she never makes, but by preservation, as chapter XX prescribes. Newt's cry of "Mommy," when Ripley rescues her a final time, is the child's declaration of the obedience Hobbes says is owed to the preserver. The film unsigns the sexual contract and returns to the clause that preceded it.

Hobbes's verse autobiography records that his mother, terrified by rumors of the Spanish Armada, gave birth to twins: himself and fear. His political philosophy derives the commonwealth from the fear of violent death, first among the passions that, as chapter XIII says, incline men to peace. Ripley's preservative sovereignty is equally born of fear—her nightmares of the chestburster, her terror in the nest—but its object differs. Hobbes's subject fears for himself; Ripley fears for a child. Fear that was the ground of submission becomes the ground of protection.

Fear that was the ground of submission becomes the ground of protection.

The year of the film supplied a legal case that rehearsed its argument. In March 1986 a child was born in New Jersey under a surrogacy contract; the woman who bore her, who was also her genetic mother, refused to surrender her; and the case of Baby M asked whether title to a child derives from contract, from biology, or from the child's interests. The trial court enforced the contract in 1987. In 1988 the New Jersey Supreme Court voided paid surrogacy as contrary to public policy, restored the mother's parental status, and awarded custody to the contracting father on the ground of the child's best interests (*In re Baby M*, 1988). The three titles at stake in that case are the three regimes of *Aliens*: generation, accumulation by contract, and preservation.

6.2 The newcomer: Arendt and Newt

Hannah Arendt made natality, rather than mortality, the central category of political thought. Each birth, she argued, introduces into the world a newcomer capable of beginning something new, and action—the political faculty par excellence—actualizes that capacity (Arendt 1958). She found the principle in Augustine, *initium ut esset homo creatus est*, that there be a beginning, man was created (*City of God* XII), and she called natality the miracle that saves the world from its normal, natural ruin.

The film's rescued child bears the name of the newcomer. Rebecca Jorden is known by a nickname that sounds the word *new*, and the amphibian it names is among the animals best known for regenerating lost limbs. Found mute, she discloses who she is—Arendt's distinction between the *who* and the *what*—only when she speaks and gives her name. Her recovery of speech is her reentry into a shared world.

Arendt's triad of labor, work, and action maps the film's three regimes with unusual precision. Labor is the cyclical activity bound to biological necessity, endlessly consumed and endlessly renewed; its subject is the *animal laborans*. The Hive is labor absolutized: an endless cycle of reproduction and consumption without a durable world. Work is fabrication, the making of a durable artifice; its subject is *homo faber*. The Company's terraforming is work perverted, a world-building that treats its builders as raw material. Action is the beginning of something new among a plurality of distinct persons, and Ripley's rescue is action. Arendt also described the rise of "the social" as the expansion of the household into a national economy in which behavior replaces action (Arendt 1958). The Hive is the social in its terminal form: a household without a polis, behavior without plurality. The four bodies of the final tableau, by contrast, are as plural as a polity can be: a woman, a child, a man, and an android, no two of the same kind.

6.3 Against reproductive futurism, without the death drive

Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) argued that politics across its spectrum is organized by reproductive futurism, the investment of value in the figural Child for whose sake the present is sacrificed, and that queerness names the refusal of that investment, aligned with the death drive. *Aliens* seems the apotheosis of the logic Edelman indicts. Everything is done for the Child; the Queen is reproductive futurism in grotesque literalism, a sovereign whose every act serves her brood; and the closing image is a child asleep under a mother's protection.

The film's futurism, however, is not reproductive. Ripley does not reproduce. The child she saves is not hers by generation, and her relation to the future is custodial rather than generative: she guards a future she did not engender. This is the orientation the dissertation calls *preservative futurism*. It neither invests the future in biological continuity, as the Queen does, nor refuses futurity in the name of the death drive, as Edelman counsels; it keeps the future in suspension, as hypersleep keeps bodies. José Esteban Muñoz answered Edelman with a queer futurity of hope, a utopian horizon not yet here (Muñoz 2009), and Kath Weston described the chosen families through which lesbian and gay communities constituted kinship outside biology (Weston 1991). The closing tableau of *Aliens* is a family chosen across the boundaries of sex, age, and kind. Its form is familial; its content is elective.

6.4 From repetition to dream

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) confronted dreams that return the dreamer to the scene of a trauma, contradicting the thesis that dreams fulfil wishes, and interpreted a child's game of *fort/da*, throwing away and retrieving a spool, as an attempt to master the mother's absence by turning passive suffering into active repetition. *Aliens* opens with a traumatic dream: Ripley wakes from a nightmare in which a creature bursts from her chest. Her return to LV-426 is an active repetition of the trauma in Freud's sense, and it takes the form of *fort/da*: the child is lost, the child is found, the child is lost and found again. Cathy Caruth described trauma as an experience not fully registered when it occurs, returning belatedly and demanding a witness (Caruth 1996). Ripley's testimony goes unclaimed at the inquiry; the film is the belated claim.

In "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) Freud distinguished the work of mourning, which detaches the libido from a lost object, from melancholia, which incorporates the lost object into the ego. In the Special Edition, Ripley's grief for Amanda threatens to become melancholic; Newt allows it to become mourning, not by replacing the lost daughter but by giving love a living object. Bruno Bettelheim argued that fairy tales help children by acknowledging the monsters they fear (Bettelheim 1976). Newt's mother told her there were no real monsters. Ripley tells her the truth, and in telling it protects her.

The film ends where Freud's theory began. Newt asks whether she can dream; Ripley answers that she thinks they both can. The capacity to dream is restored, and the dream ceases to be the compulsive return of the trauma and becomes again the fulfilment of a wish. The film's arc runs from *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* back to *The*

Interpretation of Dreams (1900). Winnicott's holding environment, the space in which a child can rest without having to react to danger, is the final image: four bodies in suspension, held.

CHAPTER 7

07

LEVIATHAN'S MOTHER

Toward a Theory of Preservative Sovereignty

THE PRECEDING CHAPTERS CONVERGE on a single claim: *Aliens* refounds sovereignty on preservation. This chapter formalizes the claim in four propositions and confronts its aporias.

7.1 Three regimes of reproduction

	GENERATIVE	ACCUMULATIVE	PRESERVATIVE
EMBODIMENT	The Hive and its Queen	Weyland-Yutani and Burke	Ripley, with Hicks and Bishop
TITLE TO DOMINION	Bearing: the sovereign rules because she bears	Contract and capital: the covenant and the percentage	Preservation: dominion lies with the one "by whom it is preserved" (*Lev.* XX)
RELATION TO BODIES	Hosts as substrate, incorporated into the nest	Bodies as vessels, assets, and expendable labor	Bodies carried, guarded, prosthetically extended
TEMPORALITY	Cyclical and monumental: species time	Linear and compounding: interest and return	Suspended and custodial: hypersleep
FIGURE OF THE CHILD	The brood, innumerable and interchangeable	The embryo as product; the colonists' children as acceptable losses	The orphan, elected rather than begotten

	GENERATIVE	ACCUMULATIVE	PRESERVATIVE
GENEALOGY	Bachofen's mother-right; Hobbes on bees (*Lev.* XVII); Maeterlinck; Creed's archaic mother	Hobbes on corporations (*Lev.* XXII, XXIX); Locke's improvement; Marx's M–C–M'; Apollo's embryology	Hobbes on mothers (*Lev.* XX); Ruddick; Arendt's natality; Le Guin's carrier bag; Haraway's kin
FATE IN THE FILM	Nursery burned; Queen expelled through the airlock	Burke killed; colony vaporized; the Company survives offscreen	Survives in suspension; annulled by *Alien 3* (1992)

TABLE 7.1 · THREE REGIMES OF REPRODUCTION

The three regimes are not merely juxtaposed; they prey upon one another. The accumulative regime seeks to capture the generative, converting the Hive's reproductive power into a product. The generative consumes the bodies the accumulative has positioned for it, the colonists dispatched to the derelict. The preservative regime is born in the interstice, from what both economies discard: an orphan the Hive overlooked, a woman the Company demoted to manual labor, a soldier the state left wounded, a machine designed as a tool and distrusted as a traitor. Its members are the remainders of the other two orders.

This is why preservative sovereignty cannot be derived from either rival principle. It is not a gentler generation, since none of its members begot another, nor a fairer contract, since none of them agreed to anything. It is constituted by acts.

7.2 Proposition I: preservation founds dominion

> *Legitimate dominion is founded neither by generation nor by contract but by the act of preserving a life one did not generate; by that act the preserver acquires both authority and obligation.*

The proposition has a textual warrant in *Leviathan* XX, a philosophical warrant in Ruddick's primacy of preservative love, and a fictional warrant in the First Law that Bishop paraphrases. Each makes preservation the condition from which every further claim proceeds, and the novelty lies in their conjunction. Hobbes derives dominion from preservation but treats preservation as a means to the preserver's power. Ruddick derives an ethics from preservation but declines to derive a politics of sovereignty from it. Asimov derives an obligation from preservation but places it in a machine without

dominion. The film unites the three. Ripley's authority over Newt, over the survivors, and finally over the field of battle derives from the same acts that bind her to them.

Three corollaries follow. First, preservative title is performative and must be renewed: Ripley rescues Newt not once but repeatedly—in the ducts, in the medical laboratory, in the nest, on the *Sulaco*'s deck—and each rescue renews the title. Second, preservative title extends across categories: Hicks and Bishop acquire it by acts of the same kind, and the film distributes the maternal function among a woman, a man, and a machine, as Ruddick said mothering could be distributed. Third, preservation generates *communitas* rather than *immunitas*. Esposito derives community from *munus*, the gift or obligation its members share, and defines immunity as exemption from it (Esposito 2010). The Company immunizes; the Hive incorporates; the preservative community extends its munus to the stranger—a colonist's orphan, a distrusted android—and binds itself to them. Haraway's later slogan, "Make kin not babies," names the kinship this produces (Haraway 2016).

The proposition's shadow falls immediately. For Hobbes the preserved owes obedience to the preserver, and Butler's Preserve shows how the preserver's dominion can become proprietorship. Proposition I does not establish that preservative sovereignty is benign. It establishes that it is sovereignty.

Proposition I does not establish that preservative sovereignty is benign. It establishes that it is sovereignty.

7.3 Proposition II: the parasitological homology

> *The corporation and the chestburster are homologous forms: each gestates within a host body—the commonwealth, the human—draws its substance from it, and emerges by destroying it. The film displaces its horror of the parasite onto capital.*

In May 1860 Darwin wrote to Asa Gray that he could not persuade himself that a beneficent and omnipotent God would have designedly created the Ichneumonidae "with the express intention of their feeding within the living bodies of caterpillars." The parasitoid wasp, whose life cycle the franchise adapts, thereby became a canonical

figure of natural evil, the creature that refutes benevolent design; Tennyson had already registered a nature "red in tooth and claw." *Aliens* inherits this theodicy and transposes it. Ripley's judgment on the species exculpates the parasitoid: it does what its nature requires and does not betray its kind. The film relocates the problem of evil from nature to capital, which does by contract what the parasitoid does by instinct, and does it to its own species.

The homology has a structural and a strategic aspect. Structurally, Hobbes's figure of corporations as worms in the entrails and Marx's figure of capital as dead labor feeding upon the living describe the parasitoid relation at the level of the body politic. Strategically, the Company seeks to parasitize the parasite. Serres observed that parasitism forms chains in which each parasite is host to another (Serres 1982). The Company's plan places it at the summit of such a chain, using human hosts to carry the xenomorph's embryos so that it may appropriate the xenomorph's reproductive power. The corporation is a meta-parasite. The creature, in this light, is capital's honest portrait: it does openly, and without a percentage, what the corporation does through covenants it intends to break.

7.4 Proposition III: prosthetic natality

> *In the film's climax the human capacity to begin anew is borne not by biology but by technē: a machine of labor, repurposed as an instrument of preservation, carries the beginning.*

The power loader enters the film as a sign of Ripley's degradation. Having lost her license, she works the docks operating cargo exoskeletons; the Company has demoted its disbelieved witness to manual labor. The climax converts the instrument of that demotion into the means of preservation. The Queen, having stowed away on the drop ship, tears Bishop in half and advances on Newt; a door opens, and Ripley emerges in the loader, addressing the Queen in the film's most quoted sentence: "Get away from her, you bitch!" The sentence is spoken mother to mother. It is not a challenge to single combat but an order of exclusion: the preserver claims her dominion over the child and denies the rival's.

The duel condenses every motif this dissertation has traced. It is bricolage, a work tool turned to defense. It is Le Guin's carrier bag become a weapon, since the loader is built for carrying. It is Haraway's cyborg defeating the goddess. It is Theweleit's armor transformed, an exoskeleton that protects not the integrity of a self against the

feminine but the life of a child. And it realizes Heidegger's distinction between enframing and *poiesis*, the bringing-forth that technology can also be (Heidegger 1977). The loader, which capital used to reduce Ripley to standing-reserve, brings forth her agency.

The end of the duel admits an obstetric figure. Locked together, loader and Queen fall into the airlock shaft. Ripley climbs free of the machine and up the ladder, opens the outer doors, and clings on as the Queen, still grasping, is expelled with the loader into the void. The prosthesis that enclosed Ripley's body, and in which she fought, is ejected with the monster like an afterbirth; Ripley is delivered from her own machine. The Queen's body natural follows her body politic into nothing. The last birth in the film is a woman's emergence from a prosthesis that has done its work.

Natality, in Arendt's sense, is the capacity to begin anew that birth introduces into the world. Proposition III detaches that capacity from birth. In *Aliens* the beginning is borne by an act of preservation performed through a machine. This is the meaning of *prosthetic natality*: the beginning is not an origin but an achievement, and it is achieved with tools. Firestone hoped technology would free women from biology through artificial reproduction. The film proposes a different liberation: not the replacement of the womb by a machine, but the replacement of generation by care, with machines as care's instruments.

7.5 Proposition IV: the counter-frontispiece

> *The closing tableau composes a counter-frontispiece to Hobbes's: a commonwealth of the preserved, plural rather than incorporated, held rather than ruled, and oriented to a future it guards rather than generates.*

Bosse's frontispiece composes the commonwealth as a single body made of many, under a single head. The nest composes the Hive as a single reproductive body made of many hosts, around a single mother. The final image of *Aliens* composes neither. Four bodies lie in suspension: a woman, a child, a wounded man, and the upper half of an android. They are not incorporated into one another or into any sovereign; no two are of the same kind; and each has preserved, or been preserved by, another. There is no head. Ripley's dominion, such as it is, is exercised only as watch: she is the last to sleep. The tableau is Arendt's plurality at its minimum, Weston's chosen family, Piercy's comothers, and the oddkin Haraway would later call for.

The critique that the tableau restores the nuclear family is correct about its form and mistaken about its content. Mother, father, daughter, and servant are recognizable, but none is related to another by blood or law; the "father" is an incapacitated comrade, the "servant" is the film's moral exemplar, and the "mother" bore none of them. The family form is occupied by preservative content. This dissonance between conservative form and non-generative content is the film's political unconscious in Jameson's sense: a social possibility that the culture of 1986 could imagine only by dressing it in the clothes of the family it was beginning to leave behind (Jameson 1981). The tableau's orientation is preservative futurism. Its future is not engendered but kept, and its last words concern whether the sleepers may dream.

7.6 Aporias of preservation

The theory would be an apology if it did not state the limits the film itself discloses. Six stand out.

First, preservation founds dominion. In Hobbes the preserved owes obedience to the preserver; Butler's Preserve shows preservation and captivity coinciding; and the child's cry of "Mommy" is at once love and submission. Preservative sovereignty can disclaim ownership; it cannot disclaim rule.

Second, preservation has a founding violence. Ripley breaks the egg-chamber truce and burns the nursery, and the destruction of the colony completes the annihilation of the local Hive; on the film's own comparison of species, this is genocide rather than pest control. Benjamin's Niobe stands at the threshold of Ripley's order. Preservation is partial by structure: to preserve these children it destroys those, and the film's refusal to mourn the Hive is the measure of that partiality.

Third, preservation is racially marked. The commonwealth that survives is white, founded on the destruction of a multiracial military collective, and narrated through a captivity plot whose history is the dispossession of Indigenous peoples. A preservative order that does not ask whose lives it is organized to preserve repeats the colonial humanism Fanon and Wynter indicted.

Fourth, the commonwealth exists only in suspension. Hypersleep preserves bodies by suspending their lives, and the preservative commonwealth cannot yet act, speak, or deliberate. It is a promise rather than a polity, and the film ends before any of its members wakes.

Fifth, capital survives. Weyland-Yutani is not defeated; it has merely lost an asset. The preservative regime escapes capital without overcoming it, and the franchise's later films return the Company to the center.

Sixth, the order was annulled. David Fincher's *Alien 3* (1992) kills Newt and Hicks in the crash of the escape vehicle before its action begins, subjects the child's body to an autopsy to determine whether it carries an embryo, and makes Ripley the bearer of a Queen, who dies by plunging into a furnace to prevent the birth. Jean-Pierre Jeunet's *Alien Resurrection* (1997) returns her as a clone bearing the creature's genome and mother to a hybrid. The franchise reached the depressive position—the recognition of good and bad mother as one—only by dismantling the preservative commonwealth and collapsing the three regimes into a single body.

Cameron's own later work oscillates in turn. *Avatar* (2009) inverts the colonial terms of *Aliens*, casting a human corporation and its mercenary ex-marines as the invading parasite. *Avatar: The Way of Water* (2022) re-masculinizes preservation, locating a father's meaning in protection, and sacralizes parthenogenesis in Kiri, born of a comatose scientist's avatar body without a known father and played by Sigourney Weaver. Cameron returned to Ripley's performer to give the generative regime a holy face.

CONCLUSION

08

“CAN I DREAM?”

THOMAS HOBBES SAID HIS mother bore twins, himself and fear, and his commonwealth inherited the birthright. It is an artificial man made to protect natural men from one another, and its legitimacy rests on the fear of violent death. *Aliens* opens in that commonwealth’s exhaustion. Its corporation has become the worm in the entrails; its army is disarmed by the corporation’s machinery; its tribunal disbelieves the only witness; and beyond it lies a natural commonwealth of perfect solidarity whose sovereign rules by bearing and whose subjects are made of human hosts. Between these Leviathans the film discovers, in Hobbes’s own neglected doctrine, a third ground of rule: dominion lies with whoever preserves the child.

This dissertation has argued that the concept of preservation allows the film’s celebrated antinomies to be thought rather than adjudicated. Ripley’s maternity is neither essentialist nor simply co-opted, because it is not generative; it is a practice of preservation open to a soldier and a machine. The film’s militarism is neither simply Reaganite nor simply anti-imperial, because its violence is subordinated to keeping a child alive—and that subordination does not purify the violence. Its humanism is neither species humanism nor posthumanism, because it makes the human a verdict on conduct and lets an artificial person pronounce it. And its politics is neither contractual nor biological, because the order it founds is constituted by acts. The four propositions—that preservation founds dominion, that the corporation and the chestburster are homologous parasites, that natality can be prosthetic, and that the

closing tableau is a counter-frontispiece—compose a theory of preservative sovereignty whose limits the film discloses as clearly as its claims.

The theory's stakes outlast the film. The juridical personhood of corporations remains contested in law and political theory. Reproductive capacity remains an object of political contest across the world. The moral status of artificial agents has become a practical question rather than a speculative one, and Bishop's claim to the title of artificial person reads differently in 2026 than it did in 1986. And the image of a colony whose life-support system becomes the instrument of its destruction has acquired, in an age of planetary environmental risk, a resonance its makers did not intend: the question is no longer only how to build better worlds but how to preserve the one already given, and for whom.

The film's last exchange is a question and an answer. The child asks whether she can dream; the mother says she thinks they both can. Hobbes's commonwealth was born twin with fear. The commonwealth that ends *Aliens* is born twin with a question—whether the child may dream—and its sovereignty, such as it is, consists in the authority to answer yes.

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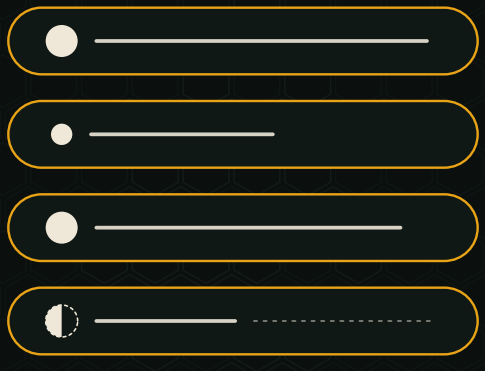
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KEYWORDS

Aliens (1986) · James Cameron · Ellen Ripley · science-fiction cinema · film-philosophy · feminist film theory · maternal theory · maternal thinking · ethics of care · monstrous-feminine · abjection · matricide · mother-right · Thomas Hobbes · Leviathan · sovereignty · state of nature · social contract · sexual contract · natality · Hannah Arendt · biopolitics · necropolitics · immunity and autoimmunity · parasitology · the corporation · corporate personhood · artificial persons · robot ethics · humanism · anti-humanism · posthumanism · cyborg theory · Marxist criticism · alienation · species-being · colonialism and empire · terraforming · Joseph Conrad · Robert A. Heinlein · Vietnam War film · Reagan-era cinema · militarism and masculinity · captivity narrative · race and representation · reproductive futurism · queer kinship · chosen family · trauma theory · psychoanalysis · feminist science fiction · Octavia E. Butler · Ursula K. Le Guin · Donna Haraway · preservative sovereignty · prosthetic natality · preservative futurism



PRESERVATIVE SOVEREIGNTY · PROSTHETIC NATALITY · PRESERVATIVE FUTURISM

LEVIATHAN'S MOTHER